

Introduction

Racing has been in decline for over a decade. Key metrics have been telling us this and action is needed now if we are to protect the sport for future generations. To some extent, the governance changes made in 2022 have helped bring together the leaders of the sport to attempt to deal with this. There are some encouraging projects, including Pace, intended to better package up the parts of the sport that could attract significant international investment, and Beacon, which seeks to provide customer insight to help the sport develop meaningful initiatives that will appeal to the consumer.

In my view, what the sport has not done so well in recent years is to follow a progressive strategy for the fixture list and race programme that supports our longer-term future, with instead there being a greater emphasis placed on commercial considerations including growing revenues in the short term. Yes, we need the best horses to maintain our place on a global level, but it is the stage that we create for them to showcase that talent which delivers this. The race programme is critical in defining the shape of the horse population in years to come so must be considered as a catalyst for it rather than an outcome.

For that reason, the approach taken by the sport to the fixture list and race programme in recent years has defined the place that we find ourselves in now. This document seeks to explore that approach, and to propose changes that I believe will lay the right foundations for the sport to change the direction of travel that we have seen in recent years. This comes at time when the approach in this area is coming under pressure as the available horse population is no longer sufficient to sustain the current model. Volume reductions may be necessary but, as well as making sure that what we offer appeals to the consumer, the proposals contained here may well mitigate the requirement and the financial implications that go with it.

What this document does not seek to do, for the most part, is provide a strategy beyond the Fixture List and race programme. That important work is already being coordinated within the sport with projects being led by organisations including the BHA, ROA, RCA and TBA. Project Beacon has provided customer insight which is also feeding into the sport's wider strategy. The focus here is very much about improving the field of play.

I am very aware that very few people will agree with everything that is written here, but I hope that the intent will be understood – for the sport to work collectively to improve what is offered to customer for the betterment of the sport.



Industry context

High Quality Horse Group

This document leans heavily on discussions that have been taking place over the last 18 months under the direction of the High-Quality Horse working group. Its members came together through a shared sense of urgency that the fundamentals of this sport – the horses and their ability to develop within the British system – have been neglected, with increasingly negative impacts for the Racing industry in this country.

The group has undertaken a great deal of work to understand the challenges that are faced. Although HQHs primary focus is to boost the supply of, and demand for, high-quality horses to be bred, trained and retained in Britain, it has become increasingly clear that this is difficult to separate from what happens across all levels of the sport.

Governance

At the outset, it is important to address the sport's governance structure. It is frequently noted that this is quite fragmented and that conflicting stakeholder perspectives lead to a lack of action. However, this is not always the case and the sport has been able to show great capability in dealing with challenges where it can unite under a common goal.

Understandably, where this is more challenging is around commercial matters, and recent abortive efforts to broaden the BHA's remit show how difficult it can be to make changes.

The purpose of this document is not to seek to resolve the future governance of the sport as a great deal can be achieved within the current structure. The focus is instead on creating a product that continues to appeal to bookmakers and customers in support of the sale of rights, the generation of Levy and, critically, putting on great sport.

Commercial Partnerships

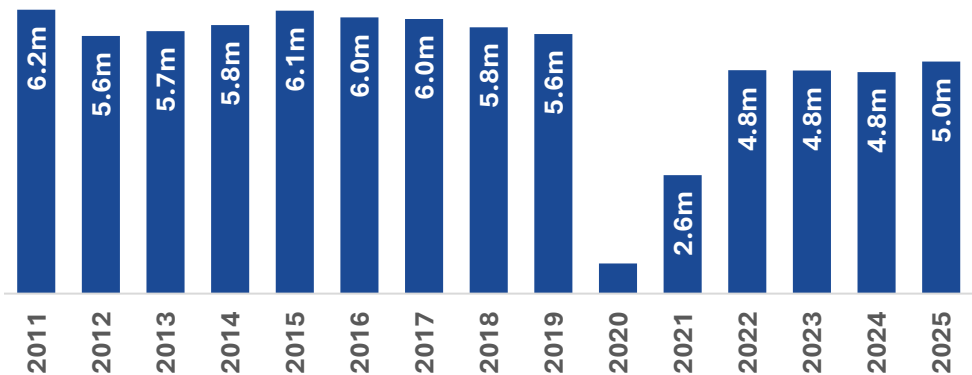
Although the aim is to deal primarily with a strategy for the fixture list and race programme, there is one essential pre-requisite: to unite stakeholder groups at the outset so that they can all share in success.

It is, therefore, critical that a commercial agreement between racecourses and the Thoroughbred Group is put in place. Although it is not the primary objective of this document to provide detail about how these would operate, a summary is included on page 23, with more detail available on the Thoroughbred Group website.

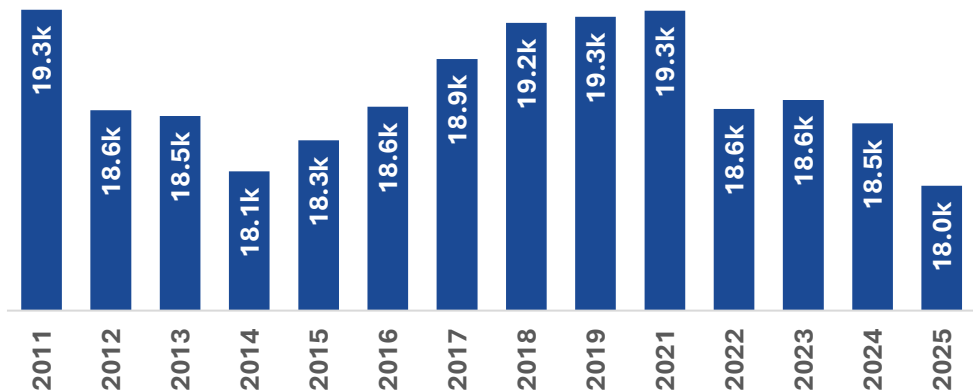
The importance of these agreements cannot be underestimated and they must be supported by the BHA.

The current state of play

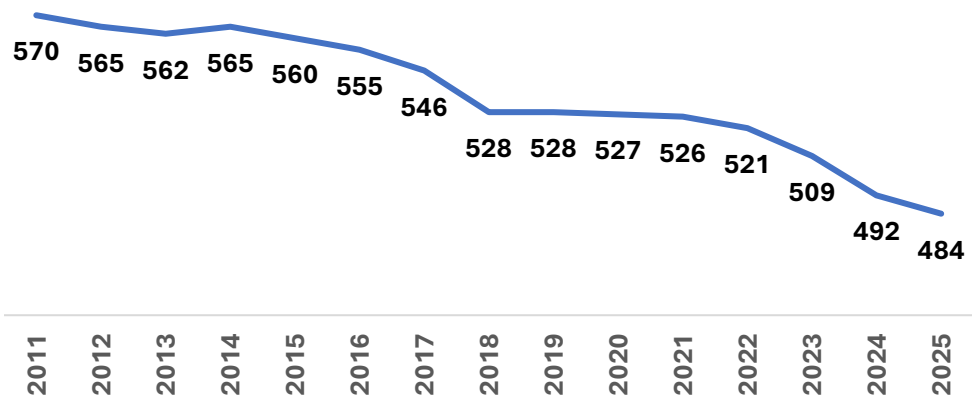
Attendances have fallen from 6.1m to 5.0m



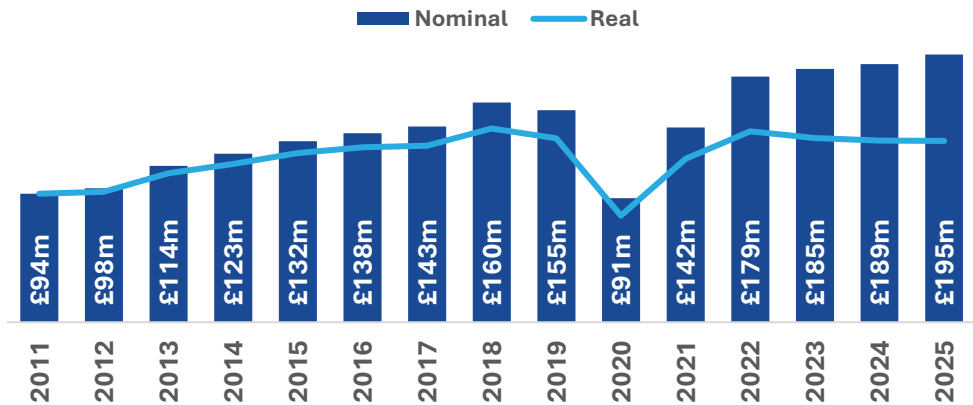
The number of individual runners has fallen by 7% since 2011



The number of GB trainers has fallen by 15%



Real-terms prize money is almost £10m below 2018's level

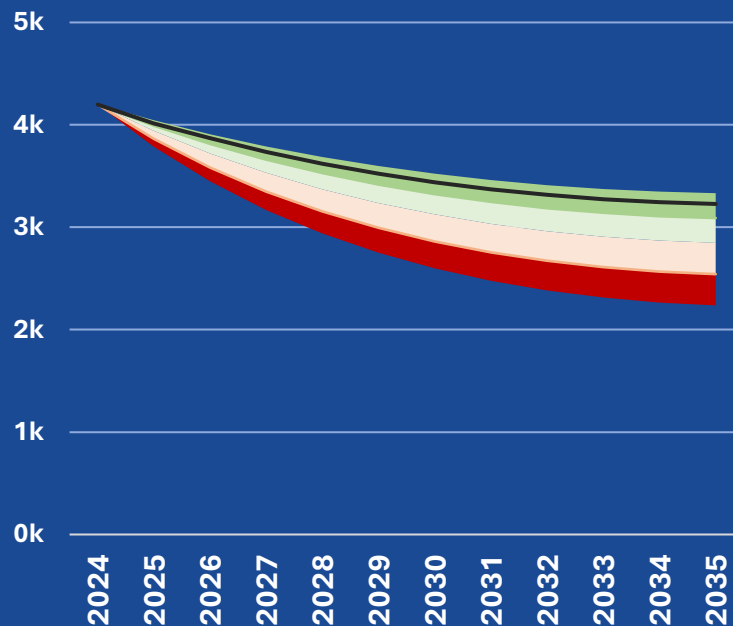


Projections to 2030

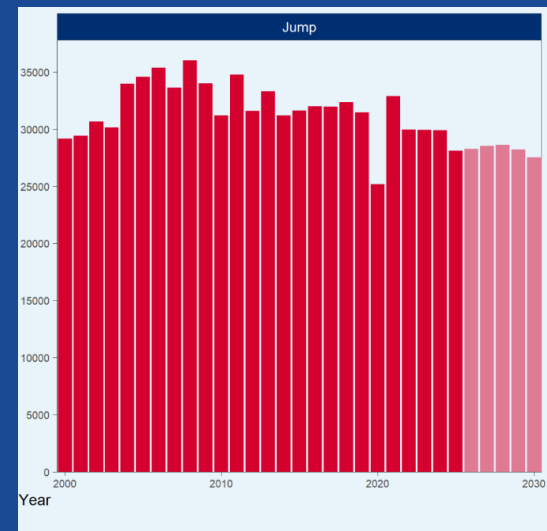
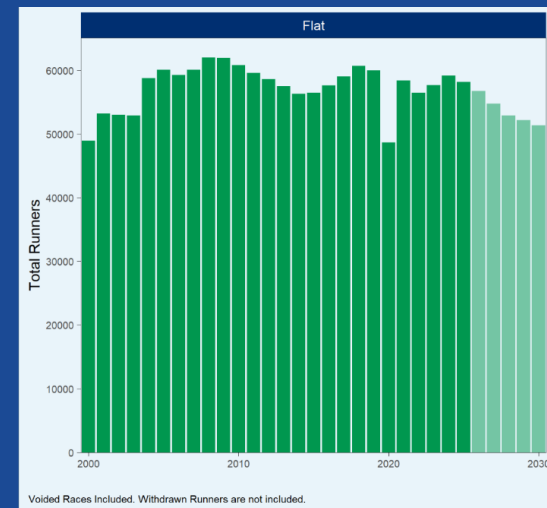
The historic data shown is useful and can be used, alongside other information, to form projections as to what we can expect in the future. One of the key pieces of data used here is TBA foal crop projections, as the lead time involved gives us a good steer on how many horses we can expect to be in GB yards in the coming years.

This data has been used as part of forward projections produced by the BHA to show the forecast number of horses in training for the next five years; a picture that is not encouraging.

TBA foal crop projections



BHA runner projections, by year and code



British racing's recent strategies have driven these outcomes

Instead of having one cohesive strategy for the fixture list and race programme, in recent years the approach has been a somewhat fragmented one where policy is driven by the objectives of individual businesses. Within this there is tension between the goals of differing stakeholder groups and, at times, the outcomes have been a sub-optimal compromise. A further issue exists that in recent years, racecourses have, understandably, focused on how to work within fixture and funding policies to maximise race volume – this has had knock-on effects that the sport would, arguably, not have chosen and which define what the fixture list and race programme now look like.

The changes that we have seen since 2011 are detailed over the next set of pages.

The sport now runs 24% more AWT races than it did in 2011

Page 6

Average field sizes have declined significantly

Page 7

The quality of the AWT programme has increased

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Funding decisions have impacted the balance of the horse population

Page 10

Prize money decisions are focused on delivering race volume rather than sporting outcomes

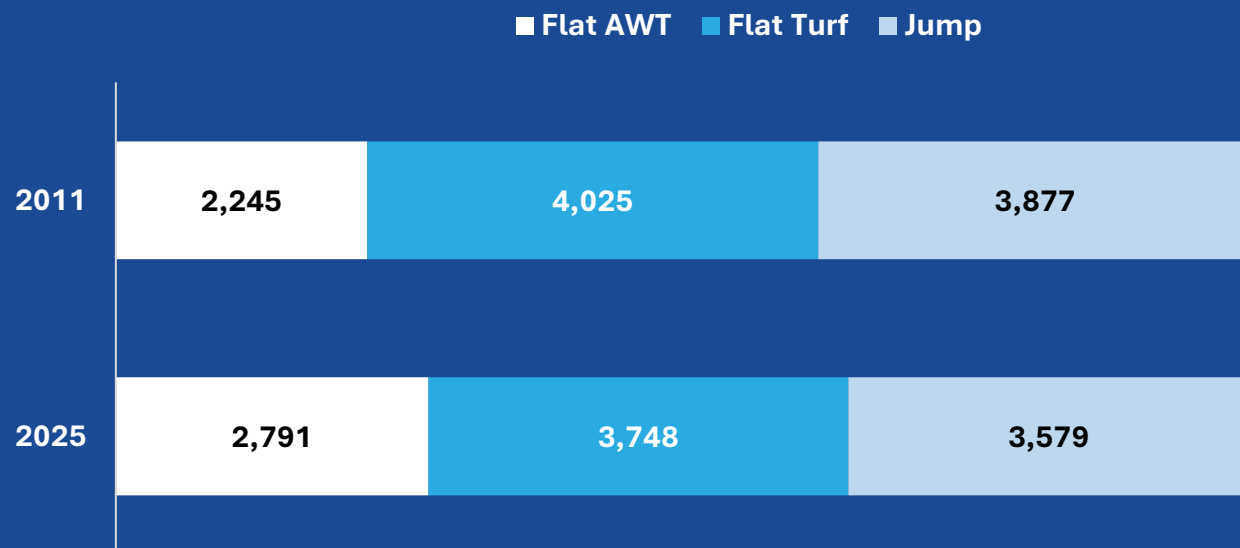
Page 11

The race programme is no longer aspirational

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The sport now runs 24% more AWT races than it did in 2011

Races run, by fixture type and year

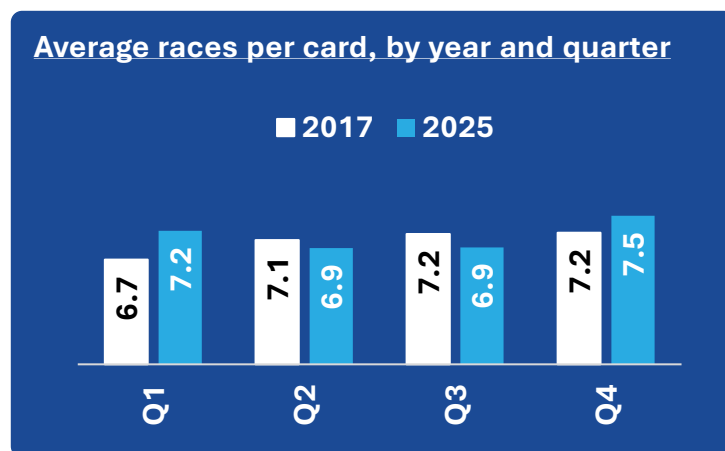
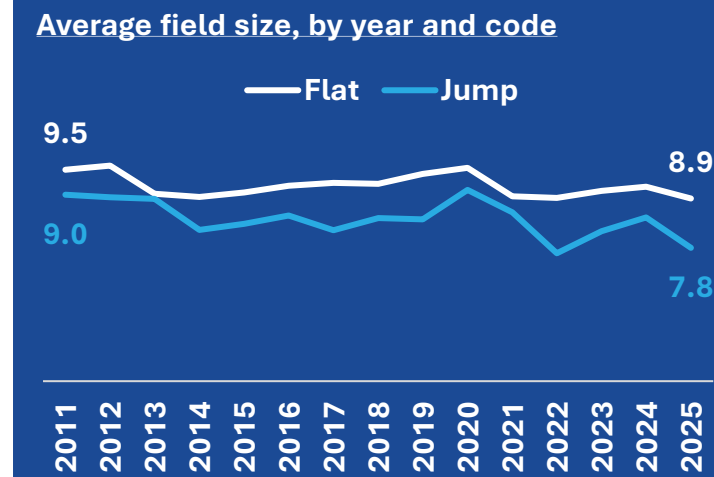


Although this has been driven partly by the conversion of Newcastle and the re-opening of Chelmsford City, this increase is quite significant given that it is not the output of any central strategy. Should Racing seek to protect its position as a globally significant turf racing nation?

Average field sizes have declined significantly

Declining field sizes have been evident for some time, and in 2014 the BHA undertook a consultation that focused on 'The impact of the fairly recent and significant decline in field sizes and increase in the number of small fields... and the ensuing repercussions on the competitive nature of racing and therefore its attractiveness to the end consumer'. At the time, then BHA CEO Paul Bittar said 'Small field races have become arguably the biggest challenge facing British Racing in recent years.'

The outcome was the introduction of some initiatives intended to drive field sizes, the most significant of which was a restriction on the number of races staged at fixtures at certain times of the year. These changes saw a reduction in the number of race staged for 2015 and 2016 but by 2017 the number was higher than ever again due to growth in the number of fixtures, and greater focus from racecourses on maximising volume and the associated media revenues.



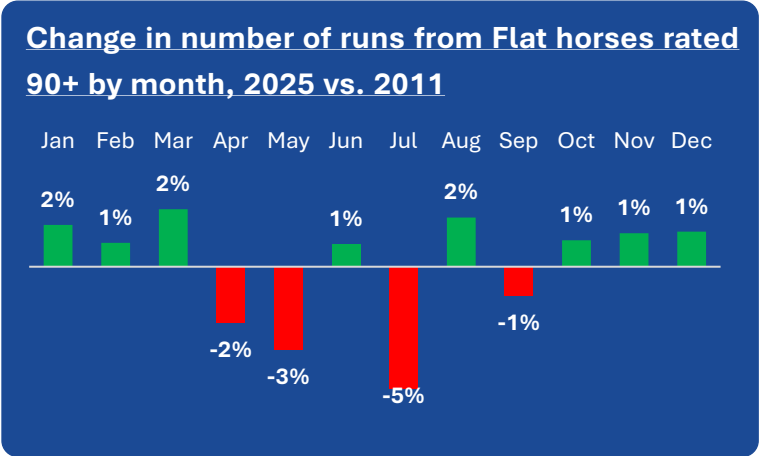
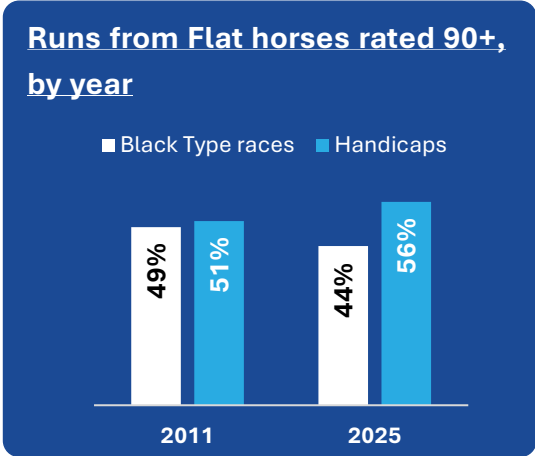
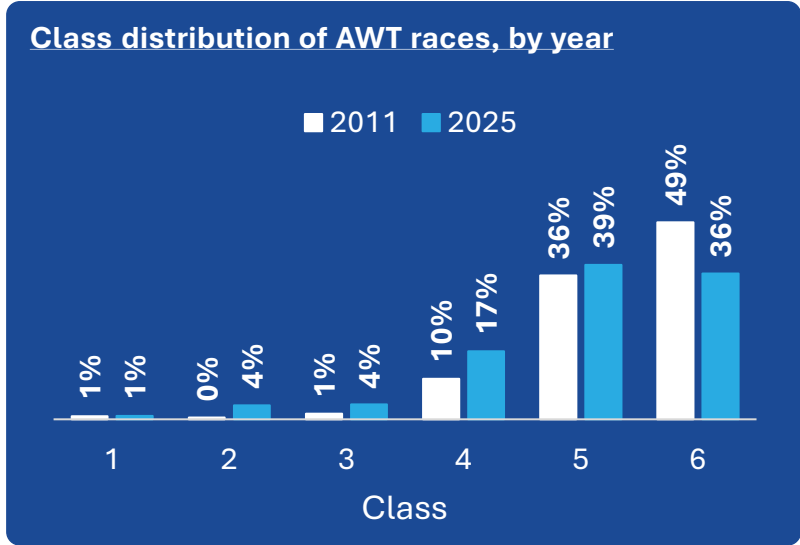
The restricting of races per fixture is an approach that has continued since that time, and we now find ourselves in a position where the following limits below the usual 7 race cards apply:

- Flat fixtures limited to 6.5 races from May to July and 6 races in August
- Jump fixtures limited to an average of 6.5 races per card all year

It is questionable whether, purely because of the long-running lack of clarity over fixture ownership, the policy adopted by the sport has been to stage exactly the same number of fixtures but with fewer races. Although this deals with the lack of horses, it retains all the cost of staging fixtures, to both racecourses and participants, whilst simultaneously leaving attendees feeling shortchanged by only seeing six races. There must be a better solution.

The quality of the AWT winter programme has increased

The introduction of the AWT Championship in 2013 brought about significant changes to the annual Flat race programme, with the introduction of a far higher proportion of Class 2 and 3 races. In 2021, Class 7 races were also discontinued with races that were previously categorised as Class 7 handicaps being reclassified as Class 6s, with many run as 0-50 Classified races.

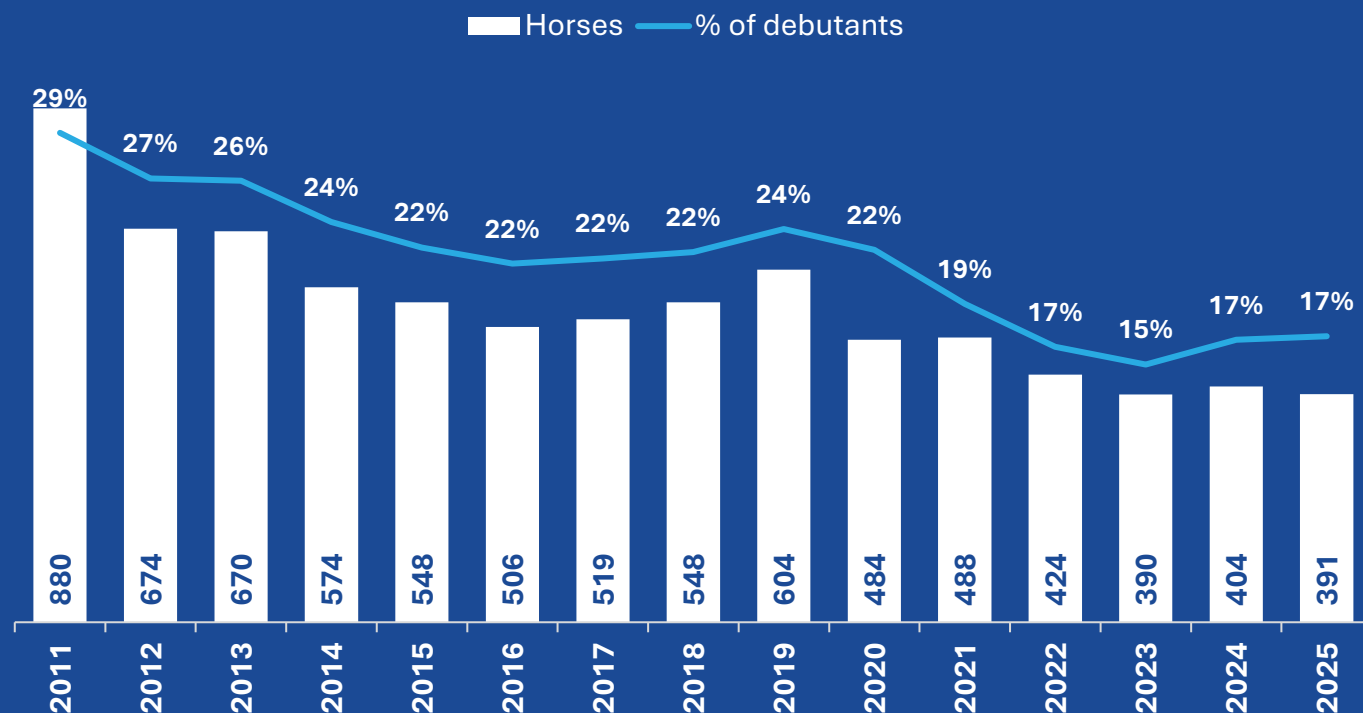


Whilst the objectives of the AWT Championships were worthy ones in trying to uplift the quality of the programme, with hindsight it is again questionable whether doing so would have formed part of a wider strategy for the sport given upcoming declines in the number of horse in training.

The spread of runners rated 90+ across the year has changed but this change has not just meant that horses are moving out of Class 2 summer handicaps and into winter ones. The actual impact is also felt across the Black Type programme. This is a problem for the sport as the proliferation of opportunities to run in handicaps over a twelve-month period has been a factor in reducing the attractiveness of aspiring to Black Type. 2025 saw 100 fewer runs in Listed races than in 2011. The lack of aspiration in the race programme is a subject that will come up again later and is affecting both codes.

The quality of the AWT winter programme has increased

Hurdling debutants with Flat experience, by year



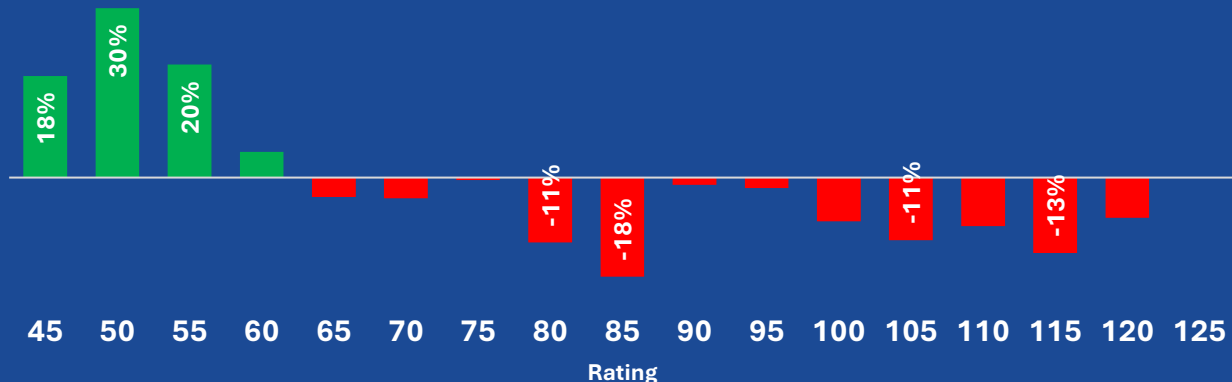
The changes made to the AWT programme have also impacted the number of horses that are transitioning to Jumps. In 2011, 29% of hurdling debutants had run on the flat, a number that has now fallen to 17%.

Funding decisions have impacted the balance of the horse population

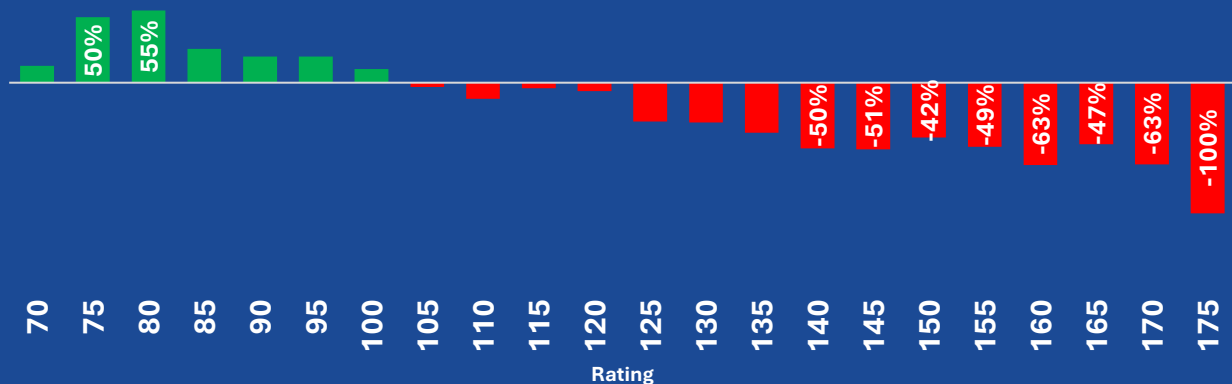
Another change that was made to the programme and its funding was the introduction of the Appearance Money Scheme in 2017. Coming at a time when Levy reform had seen an uplift to prize money funding, the scheme was intended to shore up the bottom end of the sport and help retain owners by ensuring that they could offset their travel costs if they finished in the first eight. Although this was a popular and well-intended scheme, it is again debatable in hindsight whether it was the right use of those funds from a strategic perspective.

Arguably, the shape of the ratings pyramid for both codes changed as a result of this scheme with lower grade horses being kept in training for longer. Whilst understandable that many would like to see such a scheme come back as it is helpful to their businesses, there is a strong argument that the money would have been better spent on race values more generally and in a way that rewards winning rather than running if British racing is to thrive as a sport. This is not because of any negativity towards lower grade horses, it is about the fact that it is through our ability to populate the higher grade races that we can best acquire new customers to support the whole sport. Failure to do this will cause harm to all levels.

Change in year-end ratings for GB Flat horses, 2025 vs. 2015

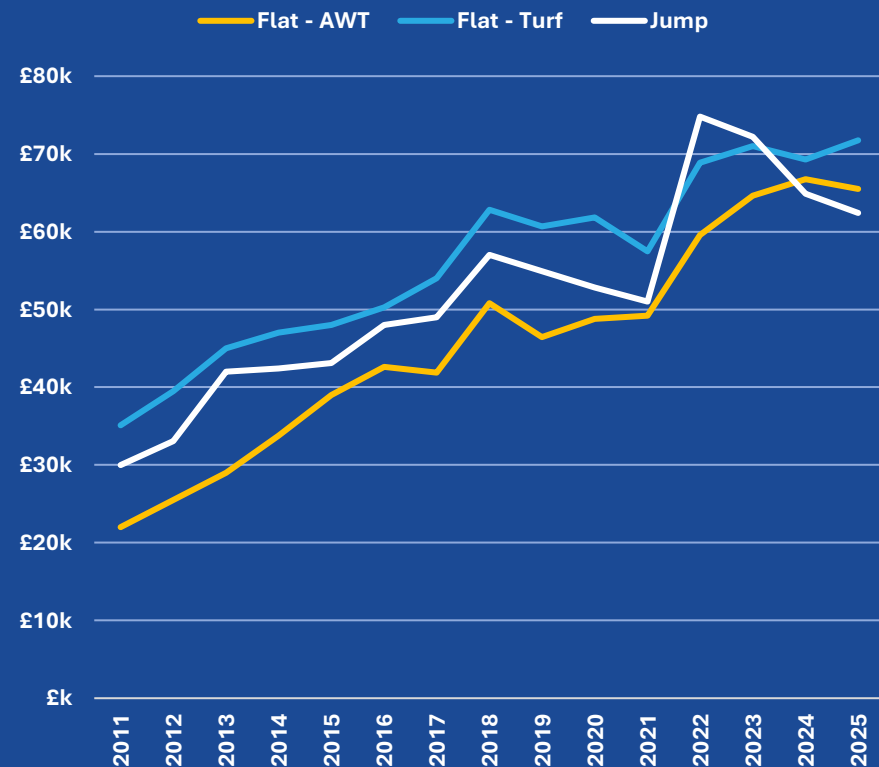


Change in year-end ratings for GB Jump horses, 2025 vs. 2015



Prize money decisions are focused on delivering race volume rather than sporting outcomes

Median fixture value, by year and fixture type



The graph illustrates the increasing desire for racecourses to work within fixture and funding policies to drive increased volume.

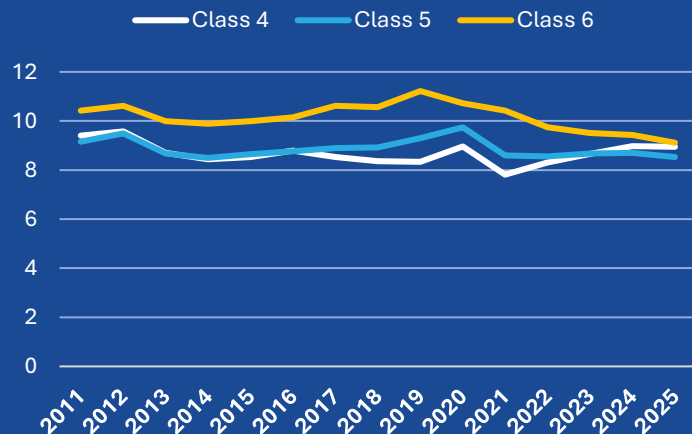
This played out most obviously in 2022, when there was a significant spike in prize money allocated to Jump Racing, something that was well received by those involved with that code. However, this was primarily a response to a policy that meant that fixtures that were staged for £75,000 or more were exempt from volume restrictions. Effectively, the policies that the sport has created led to an unintended consequence where any available discretionary spend was best allocated here. This is all well and good, but those values came down with a bump when the exemption policy was discontinued. Instead, the next best area to focus on, again dictated by policy, is the ability to secure an increased number of AWT fixtures through the BHA Fixture Allocation model (the Proportionate Allocation System, or PAS) by allocating discretionary spend to Flat races rather than Jump races due to the size of the AWT Floodlit pool of fixtures. The swing of funding out of Jump racing and into Flat was never something that would have been a strategic objective for the sport but has been delivered as an unintended consequence.

To be clear here, this is in no way a criticism of those involved in doing what is best for their business in the face of policy decisions. However, the sport should react to that and seek policies that avoid such consequences.

The race programme is no longer aspirational

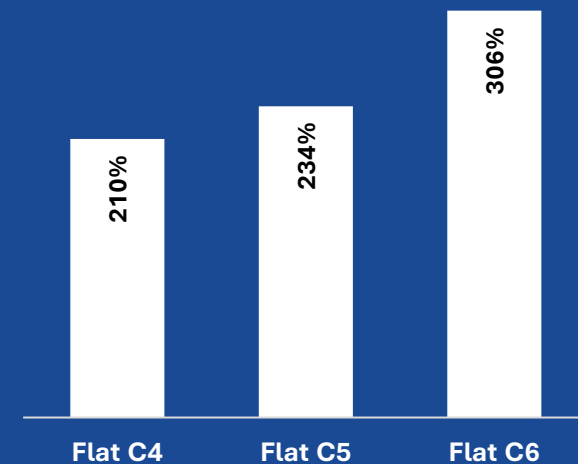
There has been an equalization of field sizes between classes via industry guidance into race planning. This sounds sensible as it, in theory, creates more races with the desired field size of 8. However, these changes have impacted the relative rewards available across the racing pyramid.

Flat handicap AFS, by year and class

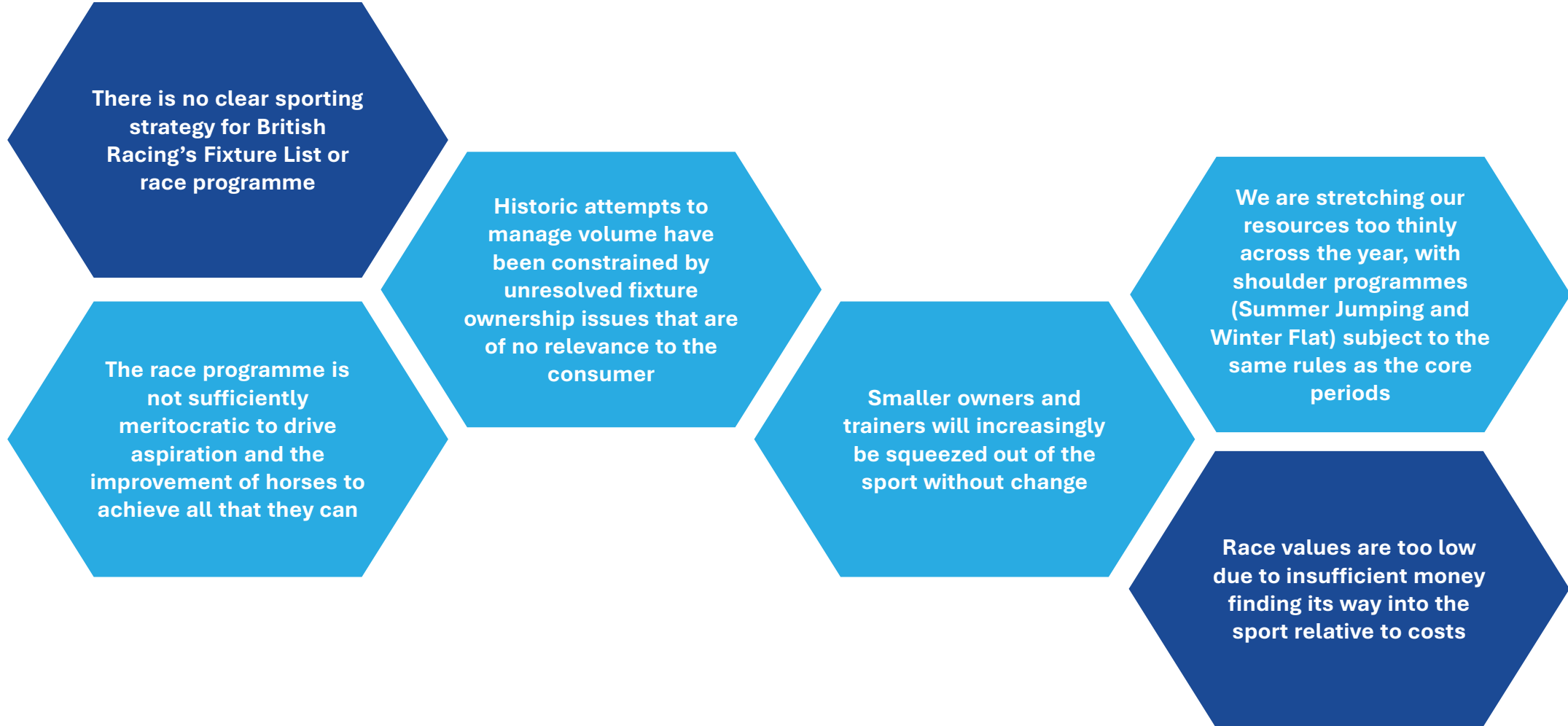


The removal of on-card meritocracy (meaning that lower grade races can be staged for more than higher grade races on the same card) has seen money diverted to the bottom classes, with horses rated below 50 often racing for more money than those rated up to 75 at many fixtures. This is another example of racecourses working within the current policy framework to drive race volume and revenue, this time via triggering divisions. This has also contributed to the higher relative growth in returns at Class 6 than Class 5, both of which have outstripped Class 4.

Change in average prize money available per handicap runner, 2025 vs. 2011



Conclusions



Recommendations

1

Define the core seasons

2

Strengthen the core season

3

Increase aspiration in the race programme

4

Optimise race volume restrictions

5

Optimise the AWT season

6

Improve participant welfare

7

Make tactical race planning improvements

8

Promote Premier fixtures

9

Agree Commercial Partnerships

Recommendations

1**Define the core seasons**

Make both the main Flat and Jumps seasons clearly identifiable, as referenced in Project Beacon's findings

The core Flat season should run from the Lincoln to the November Handicap

The core Jumps season should run from Chepstow's Persian War meeting to Sandown's Bet365 meeting

Consideration to be given to aligning trainer championships to run across these core seasons

Recommendations

1

2

Strengthen the core season**Strengthen the core seasons in order to drive consumer acquisition and engagement**

The best horses should be incentivised to run in the core seasons. By focusing the AWT programme primarily on class 4-6 races, the higher rated horses will be better funneled to the core season.

The Flat Novice race programme in January, and February should focus on Restricted races rather than Open races, encouraging the better Novices to appear before the end of each year and supporting the core season

Relief against any volume reductions to be provided to racecourses that stage turf fixtures in the opening weeks of the Flat season

Review of the impact of recent policy decisions on specific sections of the race programme, eg northern Jump racing. Address any unintended consequences

Recommendations

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Increase aspiration in the race programme

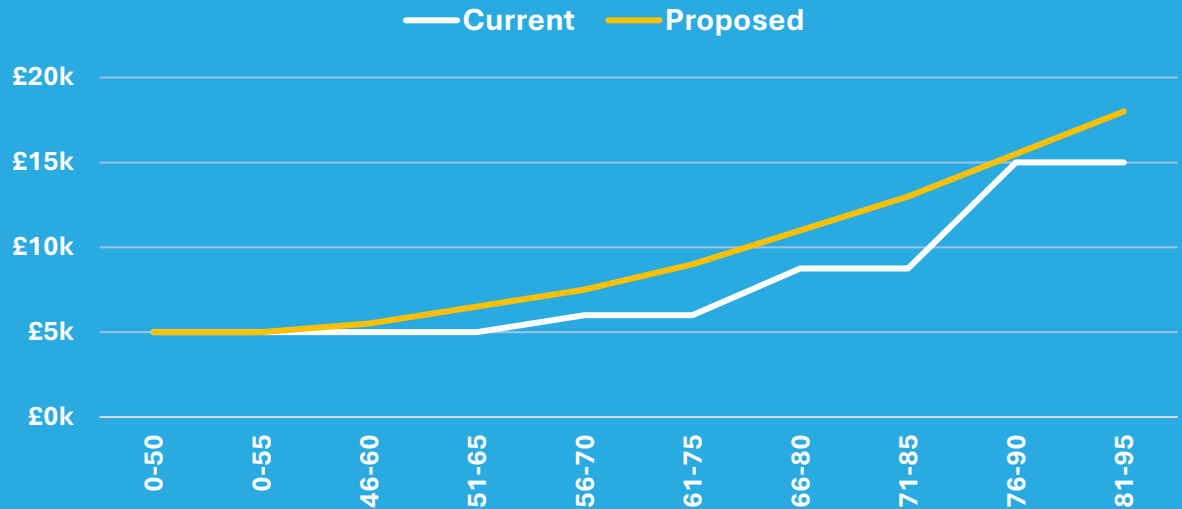


Ensure that the core seasons are aspirational in nature

An increase in Minimum Values should be incorporated into a system based on rating bands, rather than class. An example is shown below and a proposal is provided as Appendix A. These higher values should apply to the core Flat and Jump seasons. Enhanced central funding may be required to launch higher Minimum Values.

Minimum Values by Rating Band Flat 3yo+

See Appendix A (p24) for full proposed breakdown



Recommendations

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Optimise race volume restrictions



Increase average number of races per card, improving customer engagement and fixture list efficiencies

Race volume should no longer be managed through restrictions on the number of races per card

Instead, entire fixtures in the core seasons should be furloughed, with whatever rights exist protected, facilitating an increase in the number of races per fixture staged

In addition to enhancing the customer offering, this should unlock significant cost savings for racecourses, participants and the BHA which can offset the revenue implications of any volume reduction

Recommendations

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Optimise the AWT season



Ensure higher rated horses are encouraged to run at times of year when customer acquisition is more likely, and relax policy restrictions during the non-core season

The AWT programme should focus on catering for horses rated 85 and below, with races primarily staged at classes 4, 5 and 6

In positioning these fixtures primarily as a betting product, race volume, division thresholds, and field size limit stipulations should be more relaxed than during the core Flat or Jump seasons

Current Minimum Values should be unchanged for the AWT season

Recommendations

- 1
- 2
- 3
- 4
- 5
- 6 **Improve participant welfare**



Improve participant working patterns, aiding the retention and attraction of Racing's workforce and improving ability to service fixtures

Up to one day per week in January and February could feature no Jump racing (example below) and be reserved for additional or restaged fixtures during times of abandonment

Regional fixtures should be trialed in the Flat AWT season. These would see a northern and southern fixture staged each week with matching race programmes, effectively giving a day off to flat yards whilst maintaining provision of betting content (example below)

Investigate expansion of summer Jump break by one week

	Afternoon	Afternoon	Afternoon	Afternoon	Floodlit
Monday	JUMP	JUMP			FLATNORTH
Tuesday	FLAT				FLAT
Wednesday	JUMP	JUMP			FLATSOUTH
Thursday	JUMP	JUMP			FLAT
Friday	JUMP	JUMP	FLAT		FLAT
Saturday	JUMP	JUMP	JUMP	FLAT	FLAT
Sunday	JUMP	FLAT			

Recommendations

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Make tactical race
planning improvements

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Optimise the race programme's ability to cater for the horse population, and minimise race clashes

BHA to have enhanced influence over the race programme at classes 4-6, including the power to withhold funding from races that are not required

Racing Committee's terms of reference to be reviewed with consideration given to the reintroduction of independent subject matter experts

Race planning initiatives to be put in place to incentivise more suitable Flat horses to go hurdling

Racecourses to investigate feasibility of moving Guineas trials earlier to ensure sufficient and consistent lead time ahead of the Newmarket Classics

Recommendations

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Promote Premier fixtures

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Define, promote and capitalise on the sport's shop window to acquire new customers and create new revenue

Explore the opportunities identified by Project Pace

Encourage a voluntary lay-to-lose minimum guarantee from bookmakers on our Premier fixtures

Maximise World Pool field sizes by increasing flexibility around entry and declaration processes

Recommendations

1 6

2 7

3 8

4 9 **Agree Commercial Partnerships**

5



Ensure that racing's revenues are distributed fairly across the sport, and align incentives of stakeholders to unlock collaborative growth

There has been no policy defining a fair racecourse contribution to prize money since the pandemic, and prize money in real terms is now £10m lower than it was in 2018

Commercial Partnerships would see racecourses commit to investing a set proportion of revenues as Executive Contribution, with courses rewarded for their level of relative investment

Such an agreement would improve trust between racing's stakeholders, and ensure that everybody is focused on growing the appeal of the sport

For more information, see <https://www.thoroughbredgroup.org.uk/partnerships>

Appendix A: Minimum Values Proposal

Class	Rating Band	3yo+ Current	3yo+ Proposed	2yo+ Current	2yo+ Proposed
1	Group 1	£375,000	£375,000	£275,000	£275,000
1	Group 2	£165,000	£165,000	£125,000	£125,000
1	Group 3	£95,000	£100,000	£75,000	£75,000
1	Listed	£60,000	£75,000	£45,000	£45,000
2	Class 2 Heritage	£100,000	£100,000	£100,000	£100,000
2	Open	£45,000	£45,000	£45,000	£18,000
2	0-110	£45,000	£45,000	£45,000	£45,000
2	0-105	£45,000	£45,000	£45,000	£45,000
2	0-100	£45,000	£45,000	£45,000	£45,000
3	81-95	£15,000	£18,000	£15,000	£16,500
3	76-90	£15,000	£15,500	£15,000	£15,000
4	71-85	£8,750	£13,000	£8,750	£12,000
4	66-80	£8,750	£11,000	£8,750	£10,000
5	61-75	£6,000	£9,000	£6,000	£8,500
5	56-70	£6,000	£7,500	£6,000	£7,500
6	51-65	£5,000	£6,500	£5,000	£6,000
6	46-60	£5,000	£5,500	£5,000	£5,500
6	0-55	£5,000	£5,000	£5,000	£5,000
6	0-50 Classified	£5,000	£5,000	£5,000	£5,000

Class	Rating Band	Hurdle Current	Hurdle Proposed	Chase Current	Chase Proposed
1	Grade 1	£120,000	£150,000	£175,000	£200,000
1	Group 2	£60,000	£80,000	£80,000	£100,000
1	Group 3	£75,000	£80,000	£75,000	£80,000
1	Listed	£30,000	£35,000	£40,000	£40,000
2	Open	£18,500	£30,000	£20,000	£30,000
2	0-150	£18,500	£25,000	£20,000	£30,000
2	0-145	£18,500	£20,000	£20,000	£25,000
3	Open	£11,500	£11,500	£11,500	£11,500
3	0-140	£9,800	£15,000	£11,500	£16,000
3	0-135	£9,800	£13,000	£11,500	£14,000
3	0-130	£9,800	£12,000	£11,500	£14,000
3	0-125	£9,800	£11,000	£11,500	£12,500
4	0-120	£6,500	£10,000	£7,300	£10,500
4	0-115	£6,500	£9,000	£7,300	£9,500
4	0-110	£6,500	£8,000	£7,300	£8,500
5	0-105	£5,000	£7,000	£5,300	£7,500
5	0-100	£5,000	£6,000	£5,300	£6,500
5	0-95	£5,000	£5,000	£5,300	£5,500
5	0-90	£5,000	£5,000	£5,300	£5,500